

5.2 Napster



The new look Napster

Two college students, 19-year-old Shawn Fanning and 20-year-old Sean Parker founded Napster in May 1999. They originally just wanted to trade music over the Internet with their friends, however, other users latched onto this software and soon, it became a global phenomenon. In February 2001, it had 29.4 million registered users who shared 2.79 billion files in the same month. However, the major drawback of Napster was the need to connect to a central server to authenticate and then pass the control back to the nodes for further file transfer. In this kind of a system, the server maintains directories of what is stored in each peer computer. The central server directs the connections between peers. Thus, while the connection is made directly from peer to peer, a server is still necessary.

When a new user installs the client software in the computer